FLE TRIBE

WEEK 16 · WEDNESDAY · LESSON GUIDE

Environment variables, previews & routing

This week: Put your React apps online with Vercel: live links, environment variables, preview deployments and your own domain.

Environment variables

Values like API URLs go in environment variables, not in your code. In Vite they must start with `VITE_`:

```
// .env (never commit this file)
VITE_API_URL=https://api.example.com

// in your code
const api = import.meta.env.VITE_API_URL;
```

On Vercel: Project → **Settings** → **Environment Variables**, add the same names, then redeploy. Anything starting with `VITE_` ends up in the browser, so never put secrets there.

Preview deployments

Every pull request gets its own preview link. Check the change live before merging it into `main`.

Fix 404s on refresh

Add a `vercel.json` file so every path loads your app:

```
{ "rewrites": [{ "source": "/(.*)", "destination": "/" }] }
```

Roll back

Broke production? Open an earlier deployment in Vercel and choose **Promote to Production**.

Research questions

Answer these in the app, in your own words, to unlock the next lesson.

1. Why does refreshing `/tasks/3` 404 without a rewrite?
2. Open a pull request and find its preview link.

Start your research here

- Vercel: environment variables: https://vercel.com/docs/environment-variables
- Vercel: preview deployments: https://vercel.com/docs/deployments/preview-deployments